

3. Is it true that young people of today are a lost generation?

Key Terms

young people of today; generation

- The essay should discuss, in the various communities globally, the **experiences, actions and behavior of** those are considered 'young' by the society; as a group and often between 15 to 35 years old.

*young people of **today**; generation*

- **Implicit comparison** with previous generations
- Identification and discussion of the **factors that contribute** to their being considered 'lost' or otherwise

lost

- ***Being unable to find one's way*** and *not knowing one's whereabouts*; ***unable to understand or to cope with a situation***; *that has been taken away or cannot be recovered*.
- ***Without a clear sense of direction or purpose in life***

Figuratively, an individual can be described as *lost* when he is not able to find his way around obstacles that are expected in any one's life, such that he can feel defeated by these challenges and suffer ill consequences. These could include self-destructive behaviour, and mental health issues.

For the question, essentially a figurative interpretation is required, where arguments should revolve around whether the current generation of young people, as they live, work and play are able to, or not able to deal with the social, the moral, and the political complexities of today's world, such that they become *lost*, in the various sense of the word.

Possible Stand

Not True

-While being in a milieu that looks like it can cause some segments across the world to be *lost*, the majority of world's young people have stoically weathered instability and challenges, **such that the young people of today could justifiably be not labelled the lost generation**, due to their tenacity and/or a sense of justice.

The young people have **a sense of purpose and direction in life**, whether for themselves and/or for their society. They understand and are coping with the challenges of the world in which they find themselves.

Approach

A) Explain the grounds on which people believe that the young people of today are a lost generation

B) Argue that contrary to what is believed, the young people of today have in fact been unfairly described as the lost generation, having been able to navigate the tumult that characterises the world today armed with tenacity and a sense of justice they acquired because of the times they live in.

Suggested arguments

A) Explain the grounds on which people believe that the young people of today are the *lost generation*

A1. The young people of today are perceived to not possess the resilience and resourcefulness of the young of yesteryears as they did not go through the hardship that the earlier generation faced. They thus lose their way when navigating the challenges that come their way.

A combination of a relatively more affluent upbringing, and the helicopter parenting style of their parents, caused young people to seem to not be strong enough to weather challenges that come their way, with many young people falling prey to various afflictions, mentally and also become victims of self-destructive behaviour. This observation is mostly premised on observations that young people of the previous generation went through the two world wars, and other catastrophic events but they somehow prevailed and brought the world as we know it to where it is today

A2. Disruptions of all manner leads to the current generation of young people lacking adequate pathways to educational and job opportunities, leading to droves of young people in many communities losing the means to grow up and transition into adulthood successfully.

The economic shocks of the 1980s, 1990s, and in 2008 meant that across the world's population, many suffered from economic hardship but the disruptions in the last five years or so hit especially young people badly, because the one main driver of these recessions is none other than technology, which caused many of the entry level jobs that young people could formerly take up as they join the workforce to disappear, leaving many of them without a job for an unhealthily lengthy period of time.

B) Argue that contrary to what is believed, the young people of today have in fact been unfairly described as the lost generation, having been able to navigate the tumult that characterises the world today armed with tenacity and a sense of justice they acquired because of the times they live in.

B1. The young, with their 21st century competencies, are the ones leading, efforts to overcome the many challenges that the world is facing and through it, they have shown resilience that have in fact helped the other generations to find their way to weather adversity.

While the current generation of young people, most of whom are known collectively as Generation Z, or iGens, did not go through the earlier global conflicts and instability that are supposed to have hardened them, they exhibit more care for others, are respectful and inclusive of diversity of many kinds. Because of that, while they are derided for their sensitivity, “fragility” and need for “trigger warnings” and “safe spaces”, these are actually their “defence mechanisms” which they collectively harness and do good. These same qualities have led to the Global Shapers Community, a network of 14,000+ young people under the age of 30 spanning 463 city-based hubs in 150 countries. In each city, teams of Shapers self-organise around volunteer projects that address local, regional, and global challenges. Many other young people all around the world are doing their bit too in their own way and not actually being helpless in the face of the challenges that the world faces.

B2. The young people of today are riding out the tough economic and political environment by choosing alternative career and professional pathways, effectively carving out for themselves viable means of livelihood.

Rather than following the well-trodden path of traditional employment after spending their formative years in education, the young people of today are finding their way out of lacklustre job markets and recessions by being much more receptive to risks, and by being enterprising. More than any other generation before them, a culture of not being afraid to try new things is prevalent amongst youth, partly as a result of the circumstances they are born into, partly because they are enabled by their being well-versed in newer technologies and lifestyles. One of these individuals is Agustin Cortes, the founder of Learn, an online platform that provides free educational content to anyone with an internet connection. He started it in 2020 when waiting for the replies that never came from those companies he applied to after graduating.

B3. All across the world, governments and other bodies have implemented policies and provided resources that help young people navigate their way through the multifarious issues they face, such that rather than letting all the stresses of being young get to them, the young emerges stronger, being able to find their way around as they transit into adulthood.

Well-funded, evidence-based intervention measures have been introduced by some of the world’s most progressive governments to help young people cope with the challenges that come their way. One such area is mental health, an area which has become even more critical in recent times due to the social instability caused by the pandemic in the last years of so. In Singapore for example, Youth Mental Well-Being Network was set up in 2020 for the purpose of being a support network for the many young people in Singapore facing academic stress, dysfunctional family and a host of other problems. Meanwhile in the United Kingdom,

organisations like The Princes' Trust has been assisting countless number of young people to overcome their personal circumstances and find gainful employment and importantly, their self-esteem.